

Pragmatism and democracy



For John Dewey, philosophy and politics were inextricably linked. He saw his own pragmatism (see [Pragmatism](#)) as a philosophical basis for democracy. For too long, he believed, thinkers had dealt with ‘the problems of philosophers’, abstract notions of metaphysics and epistemology, when their attention should be on ‘the problems of men’. So long as political philosophy continued to be divorced from experience, people had no influence on the institutions controlling their lives. Pragmatism not only overcame this with its focus on the usefulness of knowledge, but Dewey’s emphasis on active acquisition of knowledge necessitated democracy as the

political system. Democratic society, he argued, is not formed by the imposition of a social contract, but is an organic aggregate of individual citizens, and can only grow and evolve if individuals, too, are free to grow and evolve. The aim of democracy is therefore to provide the conditions for this, and the function of his philosophy is to establish a 'moral community', largely through education, in which individuals can achieve this self-realization.